Britain's flailing economy and plummeting international status. Sunak faces enormous challenges and dangerous pitfalls that could unseat him as rapidly as they did Truss if he does not deliver in the coming month (see *Economy: The Big Four Challenges*). Post Brexit, the UK moved away rapidly from the promised land of financial opportunities and trade deals with the rest of Europe. Amid the highest inflation in four decades of above 10 per cent, the pound plummeted precipitously to 1.03 to the dollar, its lowest level ever, in late September. Food prices spiralled upward at their fastest pace in more than 40 years. A cost-of-living crisis hit all parts of the country as wages remained low. Consumer spending nosedived, with data released on October 21 showing that people were buying less than before the pandemic. Interest rates were climbing up, sparking angry reactions. Britain's famed bureaucratic and diplomatic efficiency, and the advantage of a universal language, was fast losing its steam.

A SELF-CONFESSED FAN OF *STAR WARS* AND A COMMITTED SUPPORTER OF THE SOUTHAMPTON FOOTBALL CLUB, SUNAK IS ALSO A PRACTISING HINDU, VEGETARIAN AND A TEETOTALLER

As households face the prospect of high energy bills, Matthew Taylor, the chief executive of the NHS Confederation, chose to point out how research shows that up to 10,000 people die from underheated homes in a year. And the cost-of-living crisis will create an "unprecedented number of people who won't be able to heat their homes". There will be more deaths this winter unless the government acts. Life in modern Britain has started to resemble Dickensian fiction. Spanish daily *La Vanguardia*'s London correspondent Rafael Ramos minced no words. "In literature and art, absurdism is the tendency to avoid the constraints of the logical, shun experience and reality, and give oneself over to the irrational and the arbitrary," he wrote. "In politics, this is what we're seeing in the UK."

In four months, the country has had four chancellors, two interior ministers and two prime ministers before Sunak took over. Even Russia was quick to join the jibe machine. Its foreign ministry spokesperson, Maria Zakharova, said Truss would be best remembered for her "catastrophic illiteracy". Sunak was clear about the circumstances of the change of guard at Downing Street and making changes was the theme of his first speech. Admiring his predecessor's "restlessness for change", he acknowledged that she had made mistakes. "Not borne of ill will, or bad intentions—quite the opposite, in fact—but

ROUGH RIDE TO NO. 10, DOWNING STREET

In an era surely to be counted amongst the most tumultuous in British political history, Rishi Sunak's period in the House of Commons backbenches lasted a little over six weeks. As Britain's shortest-serving PM, Liz Truss, left the arena, it was time for Sunak, at 42 the youngest premier in over 200 years, to take charge. All other milestones he touched, however, are dwarfed by that one, epochal mark: he is the UK's first non-White and British-Asian PM. His rise in the Conservative Party, though, has been conservatively smooth.

Of Punjabi descent, Sunak was born in 1980 in Southampton to Yashveer and Usha Sunak, an NHS doctor and a pharmacist respectively, who were born in East Africa and migrated to the UK in the '60s. Sunak's paternal grandfather, Ramdas Sunak, an accountant, migrated to Kenya from Gujranwala in pre-Partition Punjab; his maternal grandfather, Raghubir Berry, migrated to Tanzania from Punjab and worked as a railway engineer. Berry moved to the UK in the mid-'60s with his family. Yashveer and Usha met in the UK and married in 1977. Evidently, the Sunaks wanted the best education for their three children, and Rishi was sent to one of the most elite schools in the land—Winchester College. Thence, it was a glide to Oxford University, that breeding ground of Conservative politicians. In past interviews, Sunak, a *Star Wars* fan, committed Southampton Football Club supporter, a vegetarian and a teetotaller, has spoken about the sacrifices his parents made to send him to these two institutions, and which surely gave an early push to his career.

THE BROWN TORY

While studying for an MBA at Stanford University on a Fulbright scholarship, Sunak met Akshata Murty, daughter of Infosys co-founder N.R. Narayana Murthy and philanthrophist Sudha Murthy. The couple wed in August 2009, and have two daughters, Krishna and Anoushka. The wedding, though attended by Bengaluru's celebrities, was tastefully modest.

Sunak worked for Goldman Sachs from 2001 to 2004, following it with partnerships in two hedge funds. His political career